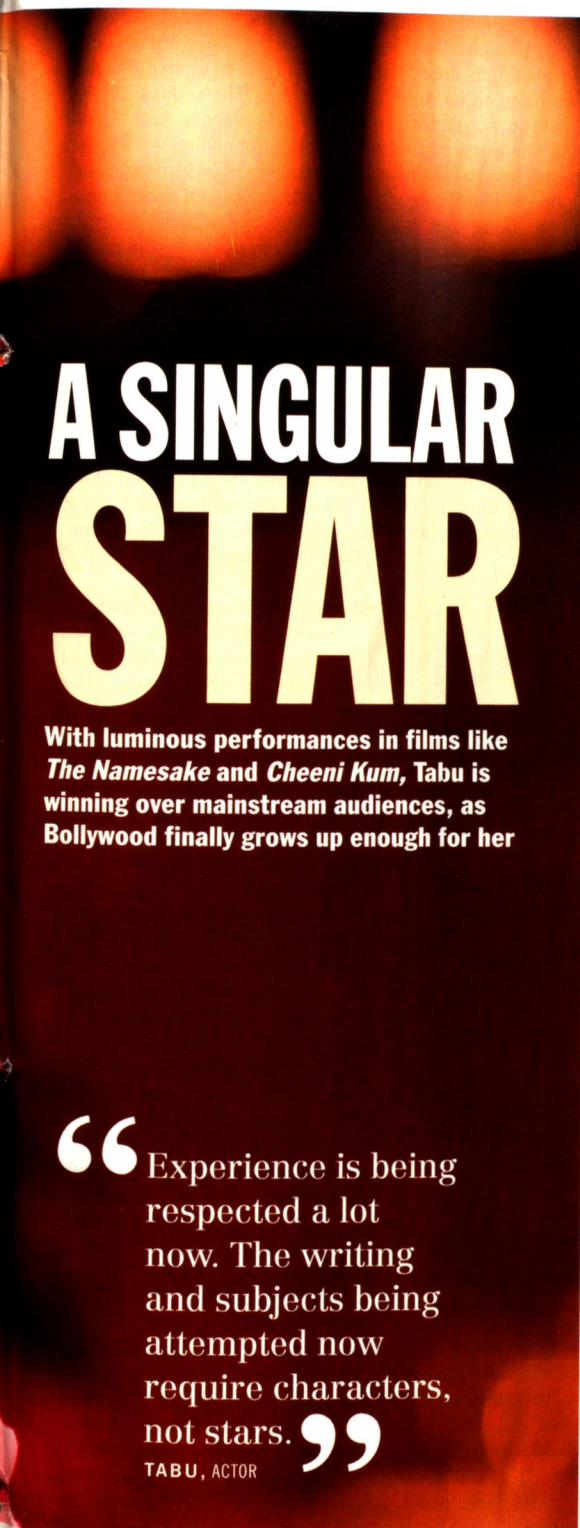




A SINGULAR STAR

With luminous performances in films like *The Namesake* and *Cheeni Kum*, Tabu is winning over mainstream audiences, as Bollywood finally grows up enough for her

“Experience is being respected a lot now. The writing and subjects being attempted now require characters, not stars.”

TABU, ACTOR

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

M. F. Husain gifts her paintings, one of which—inscribed with a verse from the Koran—adorns her living room. Gulzar gives her notebooks, on which she writes stories she invariably reads out to him. Actor Nagarjuna doles out advice, especially on where to invest—not in jewellery or designer bags but property—while choreographer-director Farah Khan likes to cook her vegetarian meals. In all this, Tabassum Fatima Hashmi, all 5 feet 8 inches of her, sits patiently in her suburban Mumbai flat with its medieval fortress doors. That is when she is not wowing critics, being featured in foreign magazines, and receiving text messages from American studio vice-presidents exclaiming about her performance.

For someone who has been in the profession for 19 years (longer, if you remember her appearance in Dev Anand's *Hum Naujawan* in 1986) and won two national awards for acting, Tabu has shown a remarkable resilience. Some of her male co-stars are now practically in their dotage, while others are clearly headed for the senior citizen's discounts—one of her first heroes (Rishi Kapoor to us and Chintuji to her) is already consigned to loveable dad roles. Her choices have always been considered suicidal (Gulzar's *Maachis* at the height of indiscriminate commercial success acquired as the girl who danced to the somewhat suggestive *Ruk Ruk Ruk* in *Vijaypath*). And yet here she is, at 35, the toast of New York with the flawless *The Namesake*, and of India, with the acerbic *Cheeni Kum*. As Ashima Ganguli, a displaced Bengali, and Tangdi Kebab to Amitabh Bachchan's Ghaas Poos, in one year, she has displayed more talent than actors do in their entire careers. It is no wonder then that *Cheeni Kum*'s director R. Balki wrote the film with her in mind: “She was the first and only face that came to me when I thought of the idea.”

While one half of Bollywood heroines was busy acquiring global aspirations and Westside agents, and another half was trying very hard to clone each other in an awful assemblage of wigs and Velcro clothes, Tabu, when not building her mansion in Hyderabad's Jubilee Hills with its water bodies and frangipani trees, was busy just living. It is the living that she distills in her work, a genuinely felt experience in a town that celebrates plastic sentiments. As film scholar Nasreen Munni Kabir puts it: “Tabu's eyes are very expressive. She gives off a feeling that life is lived internally.” It is this quality of authenticity that makes her audience embrace her despite long absences—before *The Namesake* came out in 2007, she had only been seen intermittently in the dark and edgy *Maqbool* in 2003 and the lush but little seen *Meenaxi: A Tale of Three Cities* in 2004 (“a picnic,” she calls it). Ah yes, and a taut but wasted performance as a tough police officer in *Fanaa* last year.

Tabu's singularity is evident in whatever she does. While most of her colleagues are in Yorkshire attending the BIFA awards, Tabu is seated on her couch, in a living room which has her awards stacked almost apologetically on the pelmet, discussing the plays she watched on Broadway when she was shooting *The Namesake*. “The studio would send tickets every Saturday and two girlfriends and I would go out watching plays like *Wicked* and *Hairspray*. It was such a free space.” It's the same delight with which she talks of hanging